

LeaveWell

Exit Memo

Your financial runway, decision readiness, and recommended next steps — structured for clarity, not complexity.

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Runway	Readiness	Recommended timing
16.3 months	Prepare to Leave	Sep 2026

This memo is a decision-support tool based on the inputs you provided. It is not financial, legal, or career advice.

1. Decision Summary

PREPARE TO LEAVE

You have real runway and real flexibility. A few targeted moves over the next 3–6 months would make your exit significantly safer.

16.3 months

of runway if you left today — taking you to approximately August 2027 at your current spending level.

Your savings and severance total \$85,000. At \$5,200/month, that covers just over 16 months with no income. With moderate spending reductions (25%), you could stretch to 21.8 months. If you keep working and saving at your current rate (\$2,800/mo), you would hit a 12-month runway cushion by **September 2026** — that is your safest exit window.

Your strongest move: Use the next 3–6 months to verify your real healthcare costs, build a modest income replacement plan, and reach your target savings number. You are not in crisis. You have room to leave well rather than leave fast.

Liquid savings	\$68,000
Severance (gross)	\$17,000
Estimated severance (net of tax)	\$12,750 – \$14,000
Total available at exit	\$85,000
Monthly burn rate	\$5,200/mo
Monthly burn (with 25% cuts)	\$3,900/mo
Current monthly savings rate	\$2,800/mo
Safe quit date (12-mo cushion target)	September 2026

2. Scenario Comparison

The question is rarely whether to leave — it is when. Here is what each timeline costs and buys you.

	Leave Now	Stay 3 More Months	Stay 6 More Months
Total savings at exit	\$85,000	\$93,400	\$101,800
Runway (current spending)	16.3 mo	18.0 mo	19.6 mo
Runway (with 25% cuts)	21.8 mo	23.9 mo	26.1 mo
Runway runs out	Aug 2027	Dec 2027	May 2028
Additional savings gained	—	+\$8,400	+\$16,800
Additional runway gained	—	+1.6 mo	+3.2 mo

The tradeoff: Each additional month you stay adds roughly \$2,800 to your savings and half a month of runway. That is real — but it is not transformative. Three more months buys you 1.6 months of cushion. Six months buys you 3.2. The question is whether the emotional and professional cost of staying is worth that margin.

The direct read: You are already in a financially viable position to leave. Staying longer improves your margin but does not change the fundamental picture. If you are staying primarily out of fear rather than strategy, that is worth examining. If you are staying to hit a specific target (September 2026, 12-month cushion), that is a disciplined choice.

3. Pressure Profile

Pressure is what compresses your timeline, narrows your choices, or pushes you toward worse decisions. Knowing where your pressure is — and where you have room — is how you make this decision clearly instead of reactively.

What is working in your favor

- + **Strong savings base.** \$85K total gives you a serious cushion. You are not operating from scarcity.
- + **No dependents.** Your expenses are yours to control. You can cut spending without affecting anyone else.
- + **Partner income as safety net.** \$4,200/mo in partner income exists even though your runway calculation excludes it. That changes your real risk.
- + **Moderate burn rate.** \$5,200/mo has clear room for reduction. You are not locked into a high-overhead life.
- + **Active savings rate.** \$2,800/mo while working means every month you stay adds meaningful runway.

What could create pressure

ELEVATED Fixed costs are 78% of monthly spending. Rent, insurance, debt, and subscriptions dominate your budget. Your realistic ability to cut spending in a crunch is more limited than the 25% reduction scenario suggests.

MODERATE Healthcare costs are estimated, not verified. You reported \$620/mo. Marketplace plans in most states run \$500–\$900 for an individual. If you are currently on employer insurance, verify actual marketplace pricing before deciding.

MODERATE No income replacement plan. Your runway assumes zero income after exit. Even \$1,500–\$2,000/mo in freelance or consulting work would extend your runway by 40–60%. Without a plan for this, you are drawing down savings only.

MODERATE Student loan payments persist. \$450/mo in non-negotiable debt payments continues regardless of employment. This is a fixed drain on every scenario.

Pressure summary: Your overall financial pressure is low-to-moderate. You have real cushion and real flexibility. The risks here are not catastrophic — they are compounding. Healthcare costs, high fixed expenses, and no income replacement could quietly erode your runway 2–4 months faster than the headline number suggests. Awareness of this gap is the difference between a plan and a guess.

4. What You Might Be Missing

These are factors that affect your outcome but are easy to overlook or underweight. Each one is specific to your situation.

Your severance will be taxed.

The gross figure is \$17,000. After federal and state income tax, your actual take-home is likely \$12,750 – \$14,000. The runway calculations in this memo use the gross number. Adjust your real available savings downward by \$3,000–\$4,250.

COBRA will cost more than you expect.

Employer-subsidized premiums typically cover 60–80% of the real cost. COBRA charges you the full premium plus a 2% admin fee. Expect 2–3x what you pay now. You have 60 days after separation to elect it. Losing employer coverage also qualifies you for a Special Enrollment Period on the marketplace. Time your exit around this.

You will probably spend more, not less, when you stop working.

People consistently underestimate sabbatical spending. More free time means more meals out, travel, hobbies, and incidental purchases. Budget for 10–15% higher discretionary spending in the first 3 months. Your 25% reduction scenario assumes the opposite.

Job searches take longer than you think.

For professionals at your level, 3–6 months is typical. If you plan a sabbatical before searching, add that time. A 3-month break + 5-month search = 8 months of zero income, which consumes roughly half your runway at current spending.

The identity gap is real.

Financial runway is one part of readiness. Many people who leave good-on-paper jobs experience a period of identity disruption — loss of structure, status, and daily purpose. This is manageable, but only if you have a plan for what you are moving toward, not just what you are leaving.

5. Your Next 30 Days

Based on your **Prepare to Leave** readiness, here is a 30-day action plan. Actions are sequenced by priority, not difficulty. Each one directly addresses a risk flag or blind spot from this memo.

Week 1 — Verify Your Real Numbers

- Price actual marketplace healthcare plans for your state and coverage needs. Replace the \$620/mo estimate with a real quote.
- Calculate your net severance after taxes. Call HR or use a take-home pay calculator with your expected income for the year.
- Review 3 months of bank/credit card statements. Categorize spending into fixed (rent, insurance, debt, subscriptions) and discretionary. Know your real cut floor.

Week 2 — Build the Bridge

- Identify 2–3 realistic income sources post-exit: freelance, consulting, contract work. Estimate conservatively what you could earn in months 3–6.
- Open a separate savings account and label it your transition fund. Move your runway savings into it. Psychological separation reduces anxiety.
- Talk to one person who has made a similar career transition. Not for advice — for calibration. Ask what surprised them.

Week 3 — Test the Decision

- Write down a target exit date. Even if tentative. Having a date on paper shifts the decision from abstract to real.
- Share your numbers and this memo with someone you trust — a partner, close friend, or financial advisor. Say the plan out loud.
- Write down your single biggest fear about leaving. Then write what you would actually do if that fear came true. Most worst-case scenarios are survivable and recoverable.

Week 4 — Decide

- Recalculate your runway with real healthcare costs and net severance. Update your number.
- Choose: a target exit date, or a specific trigger condition ("I leave when I hit \$X in savings" or "I reassess on [date]").
- If you are ready: give notice. If you are not: write down exactly what needs to be true. Set a date to revisit. Do not let the decision drift indefinitely.

The bottom line: You are not in a crisis. You have real runway, real savings, and real options. The question is not whether you *can* leave — it is whether you have set yourself up to leave *well*. Thirty days of targeted preparation is the difference between a leap of faith and a calculated transition. Use them.

